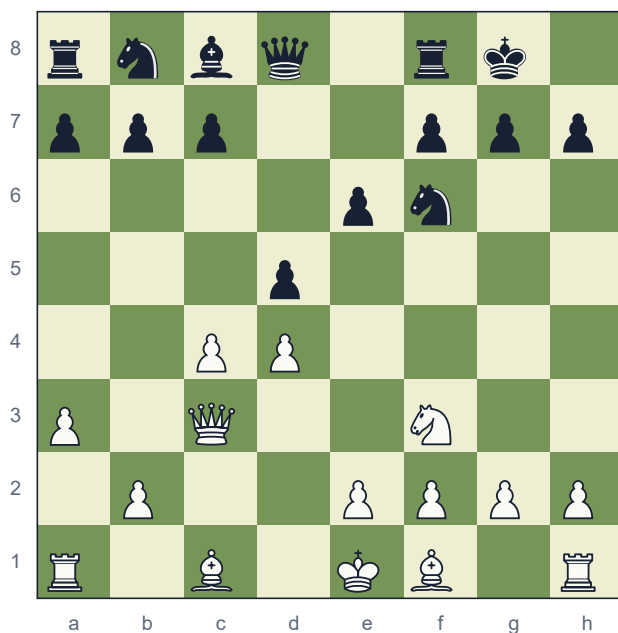


Optional expansion: the Nimzo-Indian

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Qc2

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

This booklet is optional. The main course uses 3.Nf3 to avoid the Nimzo. If you later choose 3.Nc3, 4.Qc2 aims to preserve the bishop pair without doubling the c-pawns.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

The pin on Nc3 restrains e4. Qc2 supports the knight and lets the queen recapture after ...Bxc3, but the queen move costs a developing tempo.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

Black attacks the center with ...d5 or ...c5, castles quickly, and may try ...b6. White must avoid collecting positional assets while neglecting the king.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. Do not add this whole booklet to your first study cycle unless you want to play 3.Nc3.
2. Qc2 and a3 are not free moves: account for the time they take.
3. The bishop pair is valuable in an open position, not a guarantee of an opening advantage.

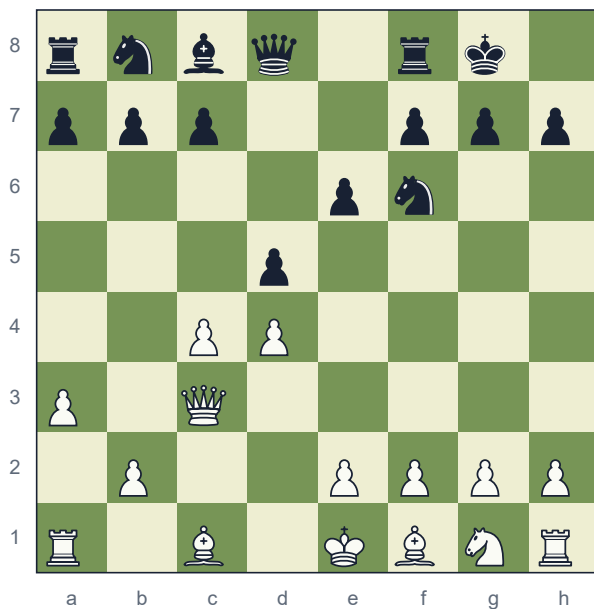
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Classical Qc2 against castling

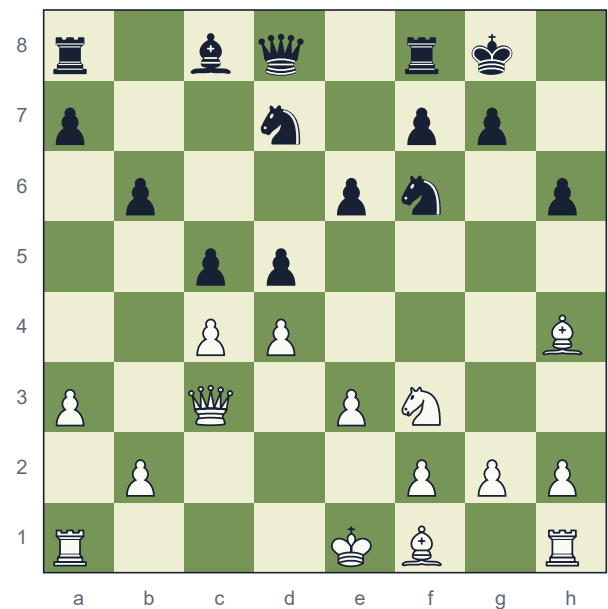
STUDY LINE 13-01

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. Qc2 O-O 5. a3 Bxc3+ 6. Qxc3 d5 7. Nf3 Nbd7 8. Bg5 h6 9. Bh4 c5 10. e3 b6

Selected anchor ends with 7. Nf3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

a3 asks the bishop to decide; Qxc3 preserves the pawn structure. Nf3 brings another piece into the center.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop the bishops, castle, and use the bishop pair once the center opens. e3 is often the practical next step.

WATCH FOR

The queen on c3 can be attacked with tempo by ...Ne4.

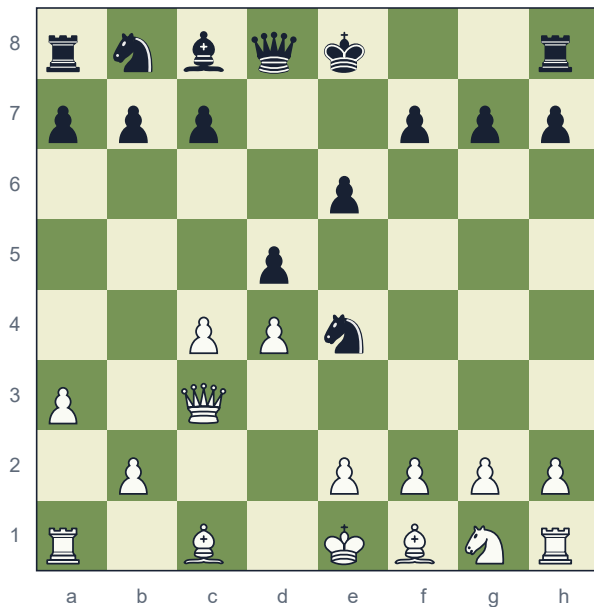
REMEMBER Keep the bishop pair without forgetting development.

02 The direct ...d5 challenge

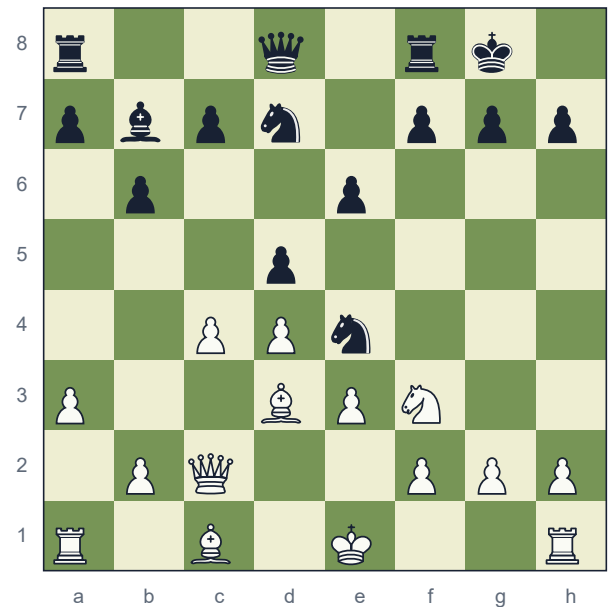
STUDY LINE 13-02

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. Qc2 d5 5. a3 Bxc3+ 6. Qxc3 Ne4 7. Qc2 O-O 8. Nf3 Nd7 9. e3 b6 10. Bd3 Bb7

Selected anchor ends with 7. Qc2. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The queen retreats after the knight gains time. You have preserved the structure, but Black has obtained active central play.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Nf3 and e3 are sensible development goals. Challenge the e4 knight only when the resulting exchanges help you.

WATCH FOR

Do not count the bishop pair as compensation for unlimited queen moves.

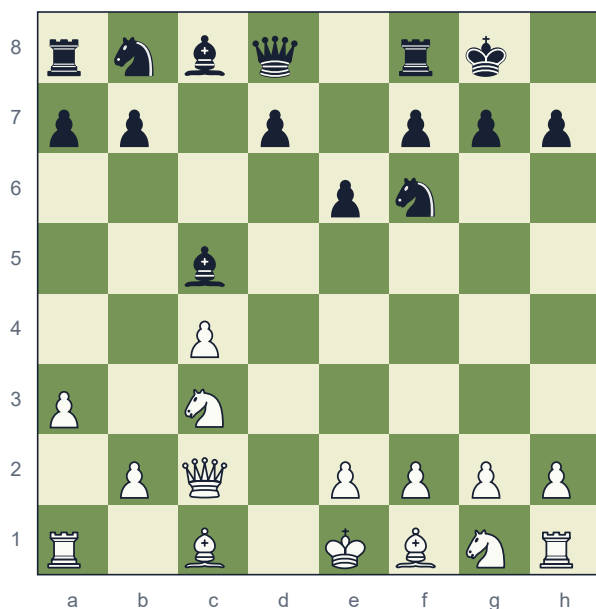
REMEMBER Positional gains must be balanced against tempi.

03 The ...c5 counterstrike

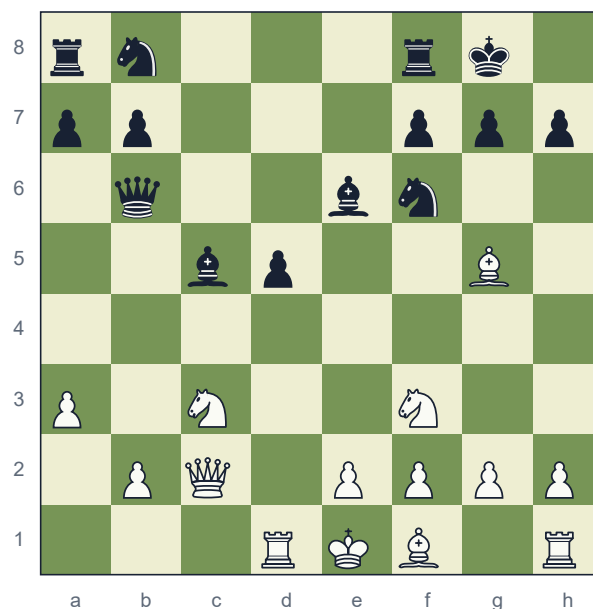
STUDY LINE 13-03

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. Qc2 c5 5. dxc5 O-O 6. a3 Bxc5 7. Nf3 d5 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Bg5 Be6 10. Rd1 Qb6

Selected anchor ends with 7. Nf3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Exchanging on c5 changes the center and lets Black develop a bishop. Your queen on c2 still helps with central control.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop Bf4 or Bg5 when useful, then e3 and castling. Keep an eye on ...d5 as Black's freeing move.

WATCH FOR

Do not cling to c5 if Black can recover it with a developing move anyway.

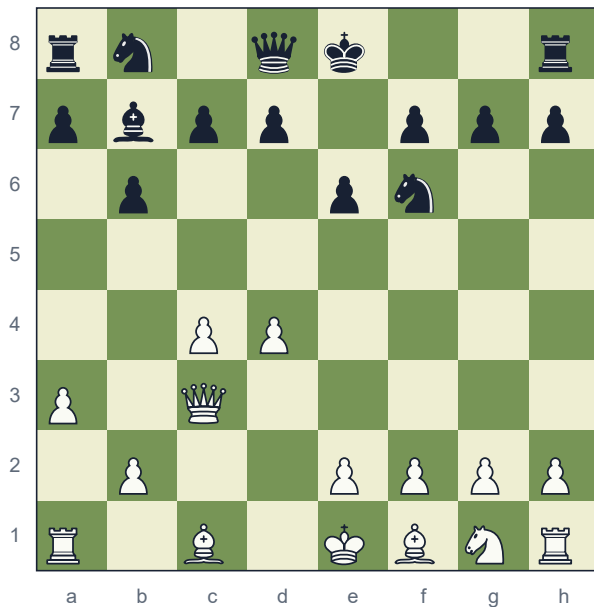
REMEMBER Use central exchanges to develop a playable position.

04 The ...b6 fianchetto

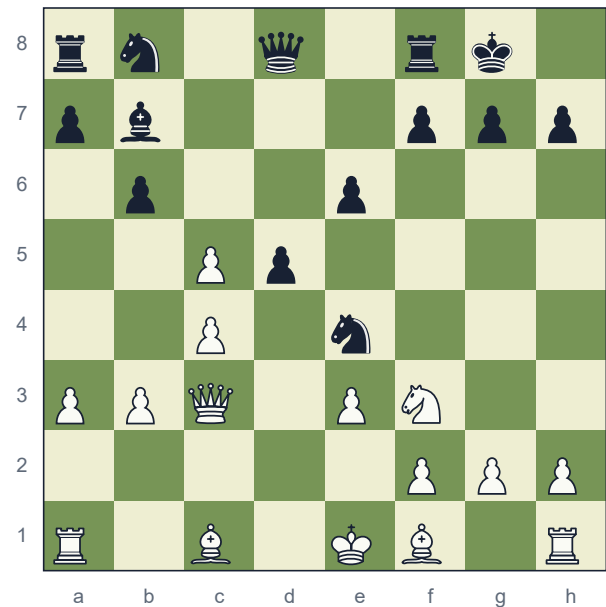
STUDY LINE 13-04

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. Qc2 b6 5. a3 Bxc3+ 6. Qxc3 Bb7 7. Nf3 O-O 8. e3 d5 9. b3 c5 10. dxc5 Ne4

Selected anchor ends with 7. Nf3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Black exchanges the pinning bishop and activates the other one. White gains two bishops but still needs to organize the center.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

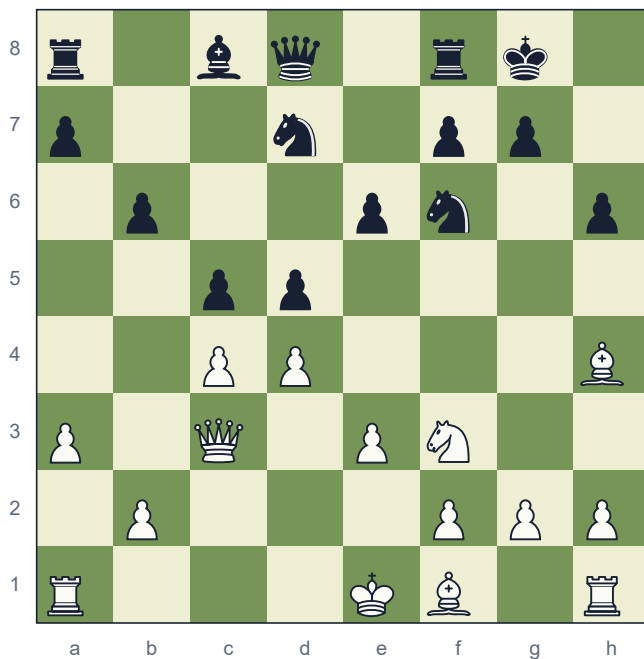
g3 or e3 can be chosen according to the central pawn structure. Complete development before opening both long diagonals.

WATCH FOR

A premature e4 may be challenged by both the f6 knight and the b7 bishop.

REMEMBER Count e4 defenders before claiming the center.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

The pin on Nc3 restrains e4. Qc2 supports the knight and lets the queen recapture after ...Bxc3, but the queen move costs a developing tempo.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

Black attacks the center with ...d5 or ...c5, castles quickly, and may try ...b6. White must avoid collecting positional assets while neglecting the king.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Develop the bishops, castle, and use the bishop pair once the center opens. e3 is often the practical next step.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.